

NESR AI Hackathon

Beginner's Guide to the Recommended Tools

Never touched one of these tools before? Start here. Each entry below covers what the tool is for, a quick visual of the flow, and the first few steps to get something working - pair this with the Guardrails and Recommended Tools sheet for what's allowed.

No-Code Automation and Apps

Microsoft Power Automate - <https://make.powerautomate.com>

Automates repetitive, multi-step tasks and connects apps and data together, without writing code.



- 1 Go to make.powerautomate.com and sign in with your NESR email.
- 2 Click "Create", then pick a template close to what you need, or start from blank.
- 3 Add a trigger - what starts the flow (a new email, a form response, a schedule).
- 4 Add actions step by step (send an email, create an item, call an API), testing each with "Test flow".
- 5 Save the flow and turn it on.

Tip: Start from a template - it's the fastest way to see how triggers and actions fit together.

Microsoft Power Apps - <https://make.powerapps.com>

Builds a working app - forms, screens, buttons - connected to real data, without traditional coding.



- 1 Go to make.powerapps.com and sign in with your NESR email.
- 2 Choose "Start with data" (Excel, SharePoint, Dataverse) or a blank canvas app.

- 3 Use the built-in Copilot prompt to describe the app you want and let it scaffold screens.
- 4 Add screens, buttons, and forms from the Insert panel, and wire them up with Excel-style formulas.
- 5 Preview with the Play button, then Publish and share with your team.

Tip: If you already know Excel formulas, you already know most of Power Apps.

Copilot and Chatbot Builders

Microsoft Copilot Studio - <https://copilotstudio.microsoft.com>

Builds a custom chatbot or agent that answers questions, takes actions, or hands off to a human.



- 1 Go to copilotstudio.microsoft.com and sign in.
- 2 Create a new agent and describe its purpose in plain language.
- 3 Add "Topics" for the questions it should handle, or point it at a knowledge source (a SharePoint site, a website, or uploaded documents) so it can answer from that content.
- 4 Test it in the chat pane on the right as you build.
- 5 Publish and share the agent link with your team or testers.

Tip: Feed it your own documents as a knowledge source; it grounds its answers in that content automatically.

Data and Analytics

Microsoft Power BI - <https://powerbi.microsoft.com>

Turns spreadsheets and other data sources into interactive charts and dashboards.



- 1 Open powerbi.microsoft.com (or the desktop app) and sign in.
- 2 "Get data" from Excel, a CSV, or another source.

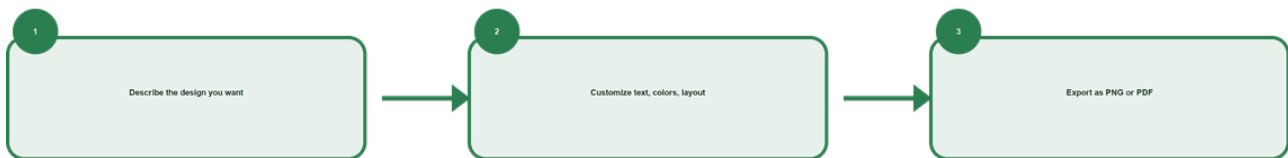
- 3 Drag fields onto the canvas to build visuals - bar charts, tables, cards.
- 4 Add filters and slicers so viewers can drill into the data themselves.
- 5 Save and publish to a workspace to get a shareable, live dashboard link.

Tip: Clean, clearly-labeled columns in your source data save more time here than anything else.

Design and Prototyping

Microsoft Designer - <https://designer.microsoft.com>

AI-assisted graphic design for slides, social posts, one-pagers, and mockup visuals.



- 1 Go to designer.microsoft.com and sign in.
- 2 Describe what you want in the prompt box (e.g. "app landing page hero image") and generate options.
- 3 Pick a design, then customize text, colors, and layout in the editor.
- 4 Export as a PNG or PDF once you're happy with it.

Tip: Great for quickly generating a polished cover slide or hero image for your pitch deck.

Figma - <https://www.figma.com>

Designs and prototypes app or website screens, and lets your team collaborate on them live.

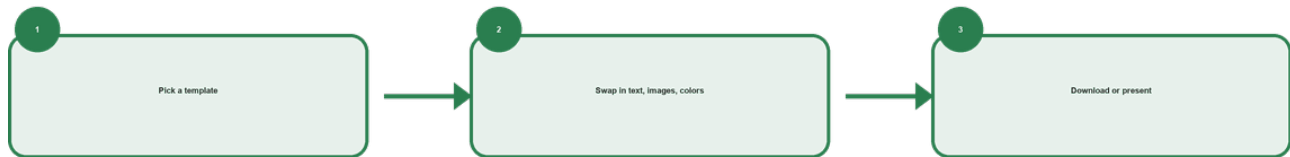


- 1 Sign up at [figma.com](https://www.figma.com) - the free plan is enough for a hackathon project.
- 2 Start a new design file, or duplicate a free Community template close to your idea.
- 3 Draw frames for each screen, add text and shapes, then link frames in the Prototype tab to simulate clicks between screens.
- 4 Share the file link so teammates and judges can view or comment.

Tip: Search Figma Community for a free template in your app's category - editing beats a blank canvas.

Canva - <https://www.canva.com>

Quick, easy design for slide decks, posters, and social graphics using ready-made templates.



- 1 Sign up at canva.com.
- 2 Search templates for what you need - "pitch deck", "one-pager".
- 3 Swap in your own text, images, and colors.
- 4 Download as a PDF or PNG, or present directly from Canva.

Tip: The fastest path to a clean-looking pitch deck if you're not confident designing from scratch.

Loveable - <https://lovable.dev>

Generates a working web app prototype from a text description - good for a quick, clickable demo.



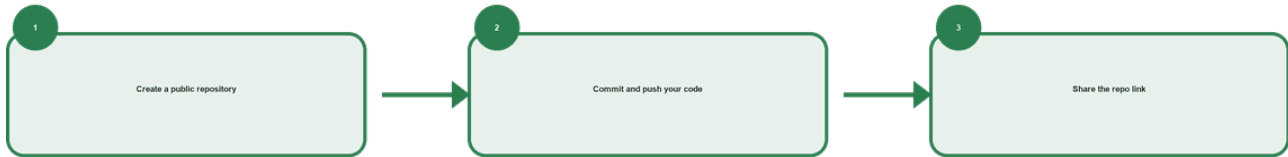
- 1 Go to lovable.dev and sign in.
- 2 Describe the app you want to build in plain English in the prompt box.
- 3 Review the generated preview, then keep prompting to adjust screens, data, and behavior.
- 4 Use the built-in editor or chat to fix anything that doesn't look right.
- 5 Publish to get a shareable live link for your demo.

Tip: Iterate in small asks ("add a login screen", "change this button's color") rather than one giant prompt.

Code and Hosting

GitHub - <https://github.com>

Stores and version-controls your code, and shares it as a public repository (public repos only - see the Guardrails sheet for what can and can't go in it).



- 1 Sign up at github.com if you don't already have an account.
- 2 Create a new public repository for your team's project.
- 3 Add a short README describing what the project does.
- 4 Commit and push your code as you build - GitHub Desktop or VS Code's built-in Git work fine if you're not comfortable with the command line.
- 5 Share the repo link in your submission.

Comfortable with the command line? These are the commands you'll use most:

```

git clone <repo-url> # copy the repo to your computer
git checkout -b my-feature # create and switch to a new branch
git add . # stage your changes
git commit -m "message" # commit the staged changes
git pull # pull down the latest changes first
git push # push your branch up to GitHub
  
```

Tip: Commit early and often - a repo with real history is more convincing than one giant last-minute upload.